

## Focal plants

These are key specimen plants that can be used to catch the eye in a bed or border, in the center of a lawn, or at the end of a pathway. Most focal plants are evergreen or have a distinctive shape or foliage form, but they can also include seasonal plants that perform for short times of the year, providing an accent when it is needed most.

Use focal plants to direct the eye to key areas of interest, or as signposts to guide the visitor around the garden. Phormiums, acers, yuccas, cardoons, and white-stemmed birches will lead the eye to a particular area or distract attention away from unsightly features, like garbage cans.

## Midrange plants

This group of plants are of medium height, and include the vast array of herbaceous perennials, bulbs like tulips, daffodils, and alliums, deciduous grasses, and, to a lesser extent, small shrubs, including compact hebes and shrubby potentillas.

Some of the most effective midrange plants rely on their leaf shape and texture for interest more than their blooms, although seasonal flower color is an important feature of many and makes an exciting statement when plants are used *en masse* in a border. When grouped together, those with strong foliage forms, such as acanthus, hostas, ligularias, and rodgersias, also create bold plantings, or they can be used to separate plants with looser flowers or foliage forms.

Midrange plants contribute to the structure of the garden, but because many are perennial, dying down in late fall and

appearing again in spring, they are not able to perform the same role as the more permanent woody plants.

## Groundcover plants

Not only are groundcover plants highly ornamental, providing a tapestry of color, texture, and form, they also create a blanket over the soil, helping to suppress weeds. Groundcover plants are not restricted to low-growing types, however, and include a range shapes and sizes, the only proviso being that they form a dense canopy.

A dry, sunny site makes an ideal home for drought-tolerant flowering plants, such as dwarf genistas, helianthemums, and hylotelephiums. Leafy groundcover plants include thyme and other mat-forming herbs, *Hebe pinguifolia*, *Santolina chamaecyparissus*, and catmint (*Nepeta*). A cool, shady site is perfect for groundcover plants such as *Cornus canadensis*, *Geranium macrorrhizum*, and epimediums under trees, and bergenias, hellebores, and ferns by a wall where the soil is reasonably moist.

## Seasonal interest

By combining different plant groups and selecting those with a succession of seasonal highlights, you can easily create a garden with year-round appeal.

In spring, focus on flowering trees, such as cherries, crab apples, magnolias, and plums, as well as bulbs like hyacinths, muscari, crocus, daffodils, and tulips that provide color. Summer brings an explosion of flowering perennials, annuals, and bulbs, offering a range of colors, heights, and flower shapes. The fall stars

are the trees and shrubs, with acers, cotoneasters and cotinus all injecting foliage color. Team them with late-flowering perennials such as asters. The winter garden also provides seasonal interest, with witch hazels (*Hamamelis*), sarcococcas offering fragrant flowers, color provided by the stems of dogwoods (*Cornus*) and willow (*Salix*), and berries of hawthorns, hollies, and viburnums.



**ABOVE Using midrange plants**

Midrange plants like hostas are ideal feature plants for a mixed shady border. Repeating plants down the length of the border brings cohesion to the design.

**BELOW Creating winter interest**

The golden yellow flowers of *Mahonia x media* 'Lionel Fortescue' make a striking contrast with the flame-red stems of *Cornus alba* 'Sibirica' in a winter border.



**ABOVE Blanketing the ground with plants**

Santolinas, with their buttonlike, yellow flowers, make excellent groundcover plants in a gravel planting in full sun, and associate beautifully with spiky eryngiums.

